Canopy Introduction and Vision - March 6 2026

Canopy

The Self-Publishing Platform Built for Growth

Sell more books. Supercharge word-of-mouth. Reach new readers.

Executive Summary & Product Vision | March 2026

The Problem

Every author knows the truth: if you want your book to succeed, you have to market it yourself. Whether self-published or traditionally published, the work of building an audience, driving discovery, and sustaining sales falls squarely on the author.

This is hard enough on its own. But the platforms authors are forced to use make it even harder. Amazon captures the customer relationship and withholds buyer data. IngramSpark offers distribution but zero audience insight. Every major sales channel treats the book as a commodity—standardized products at standardized prices—while keeping the one thing authors need most: a direct connection to their readers.

The result is a brutal cycle. Authors pour energy into building audiences, but the platforms they sell through strip away the relationship. They can't follow up with buyers. They can't activate word-of-mouth. They can't turn one book sale into a lasting reader relationship. And when they stop actively promoting, sales flatline.

> **The core problem:** Authors are expected to grow their own audiences, but every major publishing platform is designed to prevent exactly that. The tools

> authors need to market, grow, and sustain book sales simply don't exist in one place.

This isn't a niche frustration. Self-published titles reached 2.6 million in 2023, growing 7.2% year-over-year while traditional publishing declined. Annual self-published book sales now exceed $3 billion in the U.S. alone. Amazon KDP paid $650 million in author royalties in the past twelve months. The market is massive and growing—and the authors powering it are stuck with tools that work against them.

The Opportunity

The best creator tools today share a common philosophy: give creators ownership, flexibility, and the tools to grow. Shopify arms small merchants against Amazon. Beehiiv helps writers build and monetize subscriber bases. Patreon lets creators earn sustainable livings from their audiences. These platforms don't just provide infrastructure—they're built to help creators succeed.

Authors don't have their version of this yet. The publishing toolchain is fragmented across 5–8 different platforms: e-commerce, print fulfillment, email marketing, digital delivery, distribution, and landing pages. Motivated authors cobble together Shopify + Lulu + BookFunnel + MailerLite + Squarespace, spending more time on integrations than on writing and marketing. And even then, none of these tools are designed to help authors grow.

> **Canopy is the self-publishing platform built for growth.** One place to publish your book, sell it in every format, own your audience, and grow your readership—with tools specifically designed to help authors sell more books, activate word-of-mouth, and reach new readers.

What Canopy Does: The MVP

Canopy gives authors everything they need to publish and grow—in one platform. The MVP is organized around three growth levers that compound on each other: sell more books to your existing audience, turn your readers into promoters, and expand your reach to new audiences.

1. Sell More Books

Convert your existing audience into readers and earn more from every sale.

- **Beautiful book pages.** Each title gets a polished sales page with cover art, description, pricing, and purchase options. Designed to convert—no web design skills required.
- **All formats, one place.** Sell hardcover, paperback, ebook, audiobook, and the Canopy Reader edition—all from a single listing. More formats means more ways to buy.
- **Bundles and premium editions.** Create product bundles at any price point: book + workbook, book + course access, signed editions, or subscription packages. Premium bundles drive ~50% of revenue for successful direct sellers. Amazon doesn't allow this. Canopy does.
- **Personalized discounts.** Offer special pricing for bulk orders, specific groups, or limited-time promotions to drive volume.
- **Email marketing.** Built-in email suite to nurture your audience, announce new work, promote backlist titles, and convert free subscribers to buyers. Author-branded emails achieve 60% open rates versus 20% industry average. No separate tool required.
- **Customer data is yours.** Every purchase gives you the buyer's name, email, and purchase history. Build a real relationship with your readers—and own it completely.

2. Supercharge Word-of-Mouth

Turn your best readers into your best promoters.

- **Reader referral program.** Gamify word-of-mouth by rewarding readers who refer new buyers. Built into the purchase and reading experience.
- **Shareable sections.** Every chapter and section of the Canopy Reader has its own URL. Readers can highlight passages and share links to specific parts of your book on social media—driving organic discovery without giving away the full text.

- **Gift links.** Readers can send copies to friends directly through Canopy, turning your most enthusiastic readers into a distribution channel.
- **Beautiful social sharing.** Auto-generated social cards and share images that make your book look great when shared on any platform.

3. Reach New Readers

Expand beyond your existing audience through other people's audiences, organic discovery, and wide distribution.

- **Affiliate program.** Give influencers, podcasters, and partners trackable links with commission. Let other people sell your book for you.
- **Author cross-promotion.** Team up with other Canopy authors to recommend each other's books—a built-in, community-powered discovery network.
- **SEO and AI search indexing.** Every section of the Canopy Reader is crawled and indexed for search engines and AI answer engines. Your book becomes discoverable through the ideas inside it, not just the title and metadata.
- **Samples and excerpts.** Collect emails from readers who preview your book before buying—capture interest even before the sale.
- **Social selling.** Sell directly through Instagram, TikTok, and YouTube with attribution tracking so you know exactly which channels drive sales.
- **Wide distribution.** Opt into distribution to Amazon, bookstores, and libraries through Lulu's global POD network—while keeping direct sales as your primary, highest-margin channel.

Publish Once, Sell Everywhere

All of this is powered by a publishing infrastructure that handles production and fulfillment so authors can focus on growth.

- **Print-on-demand fulfillment.** Physical books produced and shipped via Lulu's global network. No inventory, no upfront costs, no minimum orders.
- **Canopy Reader.** A beautiful, web-based reading experience designed for sharing. Mobile-ready, SEO-indexed, and built to turn every reader into a potential promoter.

- **Canopy Library.** Each author gets a profile page showcasing all their books and work—their home base on Canopy.
- **Multimedia and bonus content.** Embed videos, podcast clips, downloadable resources, and author notes directly into the Canopy Reader.
- **Sales and traffic analytics.** See where your buyers come from, what they purchase, which shares drive new readers, and how they engage with your book.

Where Canopy Goes Next

The MVP is a focused product for self-published authors who want to grow. From there, Canopy expands in three directions:

More Growth Tools

- Paid ad generation—create beautiful, relevant ads with a few clicks
- SMS/text marketing alongside email
- Agentic commerce optimization—structured data so AI shopping agents can find and recommend your books
- Marketplace for books—help readers discover new books and connect directly with authors, powered by full-text search across the Canopy catalog

Editorial and Production Tools

- Manuscript formatting and interior design
- Cover design templates and tools
- Collaborative editing workflows
- Audiobook production and direct fulfillment

Platform Expansion

- Blogging and newsletter features—publish content alongside your books
- Fulfillment and logistics integrations—warehousing, bulk orders, event sales

- Embeddable storefronts—sell Canopy books from your own website
- Support for traditional publishers, hybrid publishers, and media brands launching imprints

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Target Customer

Primary: Self-Published Nonfiction Authors with Existing Audiences

Canopy's first customers are self-published nonfiction authors who are writing books to build their businesses or careers. They have much more to sell than just a book, and they intrinsically understand the value of owning their audience.

They are:

- Building newsletters, courses, and consulting practices alongside their books
- Active on LinkedIn, podcasts, and social media—they already have distribution channels
- DIYers at heart who get excited when they find a tool that empowers them
- Frustrated by the lack of control, flexibility, and customer data from current platforms
- Capable of building technical solutions but lost on marketing strategy—they need playbooks, not just tools

Pain Points

How do I get my book discovered? Discoverability on personal websites is essentially zero without active marketing. Cold traffic from paid ads is largely ineffective for books. Authors need organic growth paths that don't exist in current tools.

How do I keep selling after I stop promoting? Books have a two-week window to prove themselves, then sales collapse. Authors have no way to build compounding, self-sustaining growth. Without ongoing promotion, sales flatline.

What do I do with an email list? Authors who capture emails often don't know what to do with them. One author built 500+ emails and sent exactly one thank-you message. They need strategy and structure, not just a list.

How do I actually do promotion? The gap between publishing and marketing feels like climbing another mountain. Authors are capable of building solutions but overwhelmed by the technical requirements and fragmented platform decisions.

How do I gain more control? Amazon controls 70%+ of the ebook market. Authors report arbitrary account terminations, book removals, and nonexistent customer support. One author lost a book with 20,000+ sales and 630 reviews to automated moderation.

How do I monetize my work fairly? Authors consistently earn ~$3 on a $16.99 Amazon sale. Direct sales yield $7–8 or more. The margin gap is 2–5x—but current platforms make direct sales complex and fragmented across 5–8 tools.

Superpowers Canopy Unlocks

Turn your audience into readers. Beautiful book pages, email marketing, bundles, and premium editions—everything you need to convert followers into buyers and buyers into repeat customers.

Supercharge word-of-mouth. Referral programs, shareable book sections, gift links, and social sharing tools turn every reader into a potential promoter. Word-of-mouth is the most powerful force in book marketing—Canopy makes it systematic.

Expand your reach. Affiliate programs, author cross-promotion, SEO-indexed content, social selling, and wide distribution put your book in front of audiences you couldn't reach alone.

Get discovered. Full-text SEO and AI search indexing means your book is discoverable through the ideas inside it. Samples and excerpts capture emails from curious readers before they buy.

Publish once, sell everywhere. All formats, all channels, one platform. Direct sales as your primary high-margin channel, with Amazon and bookstore distribution as complements—not the other way around.

Market Size

TAM: Global Publishing — ~$130B

The global book publishing industry generates roughly $130 billion in annual revenue. The U.S. alone accounts for $32.5 billion, with North America representing about a third of the global market. The industry's infrastructure is dominated by wholesale-first players—Ingram Content Group ($2B) underpins traditional distribution, and Amazon controls 70%+ of ebook sales and 40%+ of all new book sales. Canopy's long-term opportunity is to build the growth-first alternative: the same scope (production, distribution, discovery) but optimized for author ownership, higher margins, and built-in growth tools. Just as Shopify armed rebels against Amazon in retail, Canopy will arm authors against the legacy wholesale model.

SAM: Self-Publishing — $3B+ (U.S.)

Self-publishing is a global phenomenon, but U.S. data is the most reliable. In the U.S. alone, self-published titles reached 2.6 million in 2023, growing 7.2% year-over-year. Output has more than doubled in the past decade, while traditional publishing titles declined 3.6% over the same period. Amazon Kindle Unlimited alone paid $650 million in author royalties in the past twelve months, equating to roughly $1.2 billion in total sales—and that excludes standard KDP sales. U.S. self-publishing exceeds $3 billion annually; the global figure is significantly larger but harder to pin down. Canopy launches in the U.S. market first, where current platforms are built for wholesale distribution, not author growth.

SOM: Nonfiction Self-Publishing — ~$750M–$1B (U.S.)

Fiction dominates self-publishing bestseller lists, but nonfiction categories like business and economics rank in the top five for ISBN registrations. Canopy's ICP—nonfiction authors building businesses around their expertise—is a smaller but significantly higher-value segment: higher willingness to pay for tools, larger lifetime value (courses, consulting, speaking, premium editions), a natural fit for direct sales and audience ownership, and underserved by fiction-focused platforms. This is the U.S. beachhead; the same author archetype exists globally, particularly in the UK, Australia, and India.

Proof of Concept: Direct Sales Work

Two publishers are already proving the direct-first model:

Metric	Damn Gravity	Holloway
Gross revenue	$147,000 (1 year)	$577,155 (since 2020)
Key metric	$99 AOV	$35 avg revenue/book
Model	Premium editions, bulk/B2B	Web-native reader, direct sales

Compare to Amazon: a typical ebook earns the author $2–3.50, and a typical paperback earns $4–6. Direct sales generate 6–30x more revenue per book than retail platforms.

Growth Path

Stage	Market	Size	Focus
Now	U.S. nonfiction self-publishing	~$750M–$1B	Business authors, thought leaders
Next	All U.S. self-publishing	$3B+	Expand to all genres
Long-term	Global publishing	~$130B	Displace wholesale-first infrastructure

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Market Context

Self-Publishing Is the Growth Story

Self-published titles reached 2.6 million in 2023 while traditional publishing output declined. The market has more than doubled in a decade. This isn't a niche—it's the center of gravity in publishing, and it's growing.

Authors Need Growth Tools, Not Just Infrastructure

The current self-publishing ecosystem gives authors production and distribution, but nothing to help them actually sell books. Email marketing, referral programs, social selling, and affiliate tools are standard in every other creator category. Authors are still stitching together 5–8 platforms to get what a single tool should provide.

The Direct-to-Reader Movement Is Real

Major publishers including Penguin Random House, HarperCollins, and Macmillan have launched topic-focused sites to capture reader data. Stripe Press, Author's Equity, and successful self-published authors are proving that direct sales work—and that readers will buy from authors they trust. The infrastructure to support this at scale doesn't exist yet.

AI Is Reshaping Discovery

Google search traffic to publishers has declined 33% globally. Answer engines and AI shopping agents are changing how readers find books. Full-text indexed content—like the Canopy Reader—creates a structural advantage in this new landscape. Books can be discovered through the ideas inside them, not just metadata.

Creator Economy Economics Work

The Gumroad model (free tier + percentage of sales) has proven effective for creator tools. Beehiiv, Patreon, and Shopify demonstrate that platforms can build large businesses by aligning their revenue with creator success. Authors are ready for this model—they've just been waiting for a platform built for them.

Business Model

Canopy aligns its revenue with author success:

Tier	How it works
Free Tier	15% royalty on sales, on top of print and transaction costs. No upfront fees. Authors pay nothing until they sell.
Subscription	Monthly fee with reduced or zero royalty. Authors keep more as they scale. Just print costs and transaction fees.

This follows the proven Gumroad/Beehiiv model: remove barriers to entry, then grow revenue as authors succeed. The free tier gets authors in the door; the subscription tier rewards and retains high-volume sellers.

Go-to-Market

Now: Author Marketing Education

Lead with content, free tools, events, courses, and community. Establish Canopy as the trusted resource for authors who want to grow their readership. This is how we find and earn our first customers.

Next: Channel Partners

Expand through hybrid publishers, self-publishing services companies, publishing consultants, and book marketing professionals. These partners bring authors to Canopy as part of their existing workflows.

Later: Paid Growth

Ads, SEM, and influencer partnerships to scale acquisition once the product and retention are proven.

How We Win and Keep Authors

Three principles:

1. **Drive real author success.** Our business model is predicated on authors selling books and earning revenue—on both the free tier and the subscription tier. We only grow when our authors grow. This means every feature, every design decision, and every support interaction is oriented around one question: does this help authors sell more books? We exist to help authors and their books succeed.
2. **Exceptional customer service.** Self-published authors are used to being ignored by platforms. We will be radically responsive and helpful. This is a wedge we can sustain against larger competitors.
3. **Beautiful design.** The Canopy experience—for authors and readers—should feel premium. Every book page, every Canopy Reader, every email should look like it was designed by a professional. Design is a moat when your competitors are Amazon's generic product pages and IngramSpark's dated interface.

Competitive Landscape

Canopy sits at the intersection of four categories. No single platform today combines publishing, direct sales, audience tools, and growth features for authors.

Self-Publishing Platforms (IngramSpark, KDP, Draft2Digital, Lulu)

Production and distribution, but no customer data, no marketing tools, and no growth features. Canopy replaces or complements these—authors can distribute through Lulu's network while using Canopy as their primary sales and growth engine.

E-Commerce Platforms (Shopify, Wix, Squarespace)

General-purpose storefronts with no author-specific features. Shopify + Lulu is the current best-in-class DIY solution, but it's $39/month, requires separate tools for email and digital delivery, and has no concept of a book, a reader, or word-of-mouth growth. Canopy replaces these.

Creator Platforms (Gumroad, Patreon, Curios, Instagram Shop)

Digital product sales and creator monetization, but not designed for books. No print fulfillment, no reader-specific sharing tools, no SEO indexing of content. Canopy replaces these.

DIY (Self-Fulfillment, Custom Websites, No Website)

Many authors operate with manual fulfillment, basic websites, or no web presence at all. Canopy replaces this work entirely—giving authors a professional publishing and growth platform without the technical complexity.

> **Canopy's position:** The only platform purpose-built for authors that combines publishing, direct sales, audience ownership, and growth tools—in one product, with pricing that scales with author success.

The self-publishing platform built for growth. That's Canopy.